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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

Environment and Natural Resources

Official Syllabus · Contemporary World Politics · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
Global Environmental Norms	Environment movement and evolution of global environmental norms; Rio Earth Summit, Agenda 21, Kyoto Protocol.	Tracing environmental milestones: Club of Rome (1972), Brundtland Report (1987), Rio Summit (1992), and Kyoto Protocol (1997).
Principle of CBDR	Common But Differentiated Responsibilities (CBDR); North-South divide in environmental negotiations.	Analyzing Principle 7 of the Rio Declaration, historical emissions debt of the Global North, and developmental rights of the Global South.
The Global Commons & CPRs	Conflicts over traditional and common property resources; management of the Global Commons.	Identifying the four Global Commons (Atmosphere, Antarctica, Ocean Floor, Outer Space); contrasting with local Common Property Resources (CPRs).
Resource Geopolitics	Geopolitics of oil and freshwater resources; international energy security and riparian disputes.	Assessing Middle East oil concentration, the 1990–91 Gulf War, and transboundary water conflicts (Nile, Euphrates-Tigris, Jordan).
Rights of Indigenous Peoples	Right of indigenous people: international law, land alienation, and self-determination.	Evaluating the UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP 2007) and understanding India's position on Scheduled Tribes (Adivasis).

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
India's Climate Stand	India's stand in global environmental debates; national climate missions and solar leadership.	Detailing India's Kyoto ratification (2002), the 8 missions under NAPCC (2008), the International Solar Alliance (2015), and the Net-Zero 2070 commitment.

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 6 Focus (World Politics)

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Date of India's Kyoto ratification (August 2002), the four Global Commons, the title of the 1987 Brundtland Report (**Our Common Future**), the eight missions of NAPCC, and the International Solar Alliance headquarters (Gurugram).

1. Evolution of Global Environmental Norms

Environmental degradation did not feature prominently on the international political agenda until the 1960s and 1970s, when industrial pollution, deforestation, and resource depletion began threatening human survival on a planetary scale.

Foundational Milestones

- **Limits to Growth (1972):**
  - A pioneering report published by an international think-tank called the **Club of Rome**.
  - Used computer simulations to warn that continued exponential economic and population growth would deplete Earth's finite natural resources within a century.
- **UN Conference on the Human Environment (Stockholm, 1972):**
  - The first major global conference on the environment.
  - Led to the establishment of the **United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP)**, headquartered in **Nairobi, Kenya**.
- **Brundtland Commission Report (1987):**
  - Formally titled **Our Common Future**, prepared by the World Commission on Environment and Development under Norwegian Prime Minister Gro Harlem Brundtland.
  - Formulated the classic definition of **Sustainable Development**: **"Development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs."**

- **Montreal Protocol (September 1987):**
  - Landmark international treaty designed to phase out the production and consumption of Ozone Depleting Substances (ODS), primarily **chlorofluorocarbons (CFCs)**, to protect the stratospheric ozone layer.

The Rio Earth Summit (June 1992)

- Formally designated as the **United Nations Conference on Environment and Development (UNCED)**, held in **Rio de Janeiro, Brazil**.
- Attended by heads of state from over 170 nations, thousands of non-governmental organisations (NGOs), and environmental scientists.
- **Core Outcomes:**
  - **The Rio Declaration:** Codified 27 guiding principles for sustainable development, state sovereignty over natural resources, and environmental protection.
  - **Agenda 21:** A comprehensive, non-binding global action plan detailing strategies to combat environmental degradation, poverty, and resource waste in the 21st century.
  - **Treaties Opened for Signature:**
    1. **UNFCCC:** United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (aiming to stabilize greenhouse gas emissions).
    2. **CBD:** Convention on Biological Diversity.
    3. **Forest Principles:** Non-legally binding authoritative statement on forest management and conservation.

2. The North-South Cleavage and Principle of CBDR

The Rio Summit exposed a profound, structural philosophical clash between the industrialized developed nations of the Global North and the developing nations of the Global South.

Competing Perspectives

- **The Global North's Position:**
  - Developed Western nations argued that global warming, ozone depletion, and biodiversity loss are collective planetary emergencies.
  - Insisted that all nations must accept equal, uniform legal commitments to curb greenhouse gas emissions and conserve tropical forests.
- **The Global South's Position:**
  - Developing nations pointed out that environmental degradation was overwhelmingly caused by **two centuries of uncontrolled industrialization and fossil-fuel burning by the Global North**.
  - Their paramount national priority is eradicating extreme poverty and achieving economic development; imposing severe environmental curbs would freeze them in perpetual poverty.

Common But Differentiated Responsibilities (CBDR)

- **Principle 7 of the Rio Declaration:**
  - Reconciled this historic cleavage by establishing the doctrine of **Common But Differentiated Responsibilities (CBDR)**:

- **Common Responsibility:** All nation-states have a shared obligation to protect and restore the Earth's ecosystem.
- **Differentiated Responsibility:** States bear **different degrees of responsibility** based on their historical contributions to global emissions and their financial, technological capabilities.

- **The Kyoto Protocol (December 1997):**
  - Operationalized CBDR by creating legally binding greenhouse gas reduction targets for developed industrialized countries (designated as **Annex-I parties**), requiring them to reduce collective emissions by an average of 5.2% below 1990 levels.
  - **Exemption of Developing Countries:** Developing nations—including India and China—were **exempted from binding emission reduction targets**, acknowledging their low per-capita emissions and development priorities.
- **The Paris Agreement (2015):**
  - Replaced the top-down Kyoto framework with bottom-up, voluntary **Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs)** submitted by all member nations, aiming to limit global average temperature rise to **well below 2°C** above pre-industrial levels, with efforts toward 1.5°C.

3. The Global Commons and Common Property Resources

Defining the Four Global Commons

- **The Global Commons:** Natural resource domains and geographical areas that fall outside the sovereign political jurisdiction of any single nation-state, requiring multilateral governance.
- **The Four Recognized Global Commons:**
  1. **The Earth's Atmosphere**
  2. **Antarctica**
  3. **The Ocean Floor (Deep Seabed)**
  4. **Outer Space**
- **Governance Regimes:**
  - **Antarctic Treaty (1959):** Demilitarized Antarctica, froze territorial sovereignty claims, and dedicated the entire continent to peaceful scientific research. Followed by the 1991 Madrid Protocol on Environmental Protection.
  - **Outer Space Treaty (1967):** Declared outer space and celestial bodies as the "province of all mankind", prohibiting national appropriation or deployment of weapons of mass destruction.
  - **UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS, 1982):** Declared the international seabed as the "common heritage of mankind".
  - **Montreal Protocol (1987):** Protected the atmospheric ozone layer.

Common Property Resources (CPRs)

- **Local Communal Ecosystems:** Refers to resources owned and managed collectively by a village, tribe, or local community (e.g., village pastures, community forests, sacred groves, ponds, irrigation tanks).

- **Threats & Marginalisation:** Privatisation, commercial logging, state enclosures, and industrial dam projects have dismantled customary community ownership, driving rural peasants and tribal communities into destitution (**the "Tragedy of the Commons"**).

4. Resource Geopolitics: Oil and Water

Throughout human history, access to and control over critical natural resources has triggered interstate warfare, imperial conquest, and strategic rivalries.

The Geopolitics of Oil

- **Energy Dominance:** Modern industrialized economies, military transport, and global supply chains remain utterly dependent on petroleum crude oil.
- **Concentration in the Middle East:**
  - The Persian Gulf region accounts for approximately **64% of known global oil reserves** and is the premier exporter of petroleum.
  - **Saudi Arabia** holds roughly one-fifth of the world's total conventional oil reserves, followed by Iraq, Iran, UAE, and Kuwait.
- **Strategic Interventions:**
  - The **1990–1991 First Gulf War** (Operation Desert Storm) was launched by a US-led coalition to liberate Kuwait and protect Saudi oil fields from Iraqi annexation.
  - The **2003 US invasion of Iraq** was widely criticized as an intervention motivated by control over Iraq's vast oil reserves and pipeline networks.

Water Geopolitics ("Water Wars")

- **Freshwater Scarcity:** Freshwater constitutes less than 1% of total global water; rapid population growth and climate change have exacerbated river basin disputes.
- **Riparian Flashpoints:**
  - **Euphrates-Tigris Rivers:** Upstream dam construction in Turkey (GAP project) has severely reduced downstream water flows to Syria and Iraq.
  - **Jordan River Basin:** Fierce conflict among Israel, Jordan, Syria, and Palestinians over access to the Jordan River and underground West Bank aquifers.
  - **The River Nile:** Massive dispute over Ethiopia's construction of the **Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD)**, fiercely opposed by downstream Egypt.
  - **South Asia:** The Indus River system (governed by the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty between India and Pakistan) and the Brahmaputra River (Chinese upstream dam building).

5. Rights of Indigenous Peoples

The struggle of indigenous communities represents one of the most poignant non-traditional security and human rights battles in the modern world.

Definition and Global Demographics

- **Definition:** Indigenous populations comprise the descendants of the original inhabitants of a territory who lived there prior to colonization, conquest, or the establishment of present state boundaries.
- **Global Scope:** Roughly **300 million indigenous people** inhabit over 70 countries worldwide (e.g., Native American tribes in the US and Canada, the Inuit of the Arctic, the Maori of New Zealand, Aborigines of Australia, and indigenous tribes of Latin America).
- **Core Grievance:** Systematic alienation from their ancestral lands, destruction of sacred forests by multinational mining, logging, and oil conglomerates, and forced cultural assimilation.

International Recognition

- The **United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP)** was adopted by the UN General Assembly in September 2007, recognizing their rights to land ownership, self-determination, and protection of traditional cultural heritage.

India's Unique Stand on Indigenous Peoples

- **The Indian Context:** India maintains that the international concept of "indigenous peoples" (developed in the context of European settler colonialism in the Americas and Australasia) does not apply to the Indian subcontinent, where diverse communities have lived together for millennia.
- **Constitutional Protection:** In India, tribal populations are categorized as **Scheduled Tribes (Adivasis)**, comprising roughly **8.6% of the national population** (over 104 million citizens).
- **Constitutional Safeguards:** The Fifth and Sixth Schedules of the Constitution provide special autonomous administrative status and protect tribal lands from alienation to non-tribals.

6. India's Stand in Global Environmental Debates

India has been a pivotal voice for the Global South in international climate diplomacy, articulating a balanced position that champions climate action without compromising poverty eradication.

Fundamental Principles of India's Diplomacy

- **Defense of CBDR and Climate Justice:**
  - India has consistently argued that industrialized nations must honor their historical carbon debt and transfer green technology and concessional climate finance ($100 billion annual pledge) to the developing world.
  - Emphasizes that **India's historical cumulative emissions are less than 4%**, and its per-capita carbon emissions (roughly 1.9 tonnes) remain less than half the global average and one-seventh that of the United States.
- **Kyoto Protocol Ratification (August 2002):**

- India signed and ratified the Kyoto Protocol in **August 2002**, defending the principle that developing nations should not be subjected to binding emission cuts during their initial development phases.

Domestic Climate Initiatives: NAPCC (2008)

In June 2008, Prime Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh released India's **National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC)**, comprising **Eight National Missions**:

- **1. National Solar Mission:** Aiming to establish India as a global leader in solar energy generation.
- **2. National Mission for Enhanced Energy Efficiency:** Promoting energy conservation across heavy industrial sectors (PAT scheme).
- **3. National Mission on Sustainable Habitat:** Upgrading urban mass transit, waste management, and energy-efficient building architecture.
- **4. National Water Mission:** Conserving water resources and enhancing water use efficiency by 20%.
- **5. National Mission for Sustaining the Himalayan Ecosystem:** Monitoring glacial melt and protecting biodiversity in the Himalayas.
- **6. National Mission for a Green India:** Large-scale afforestation targeting 5 million hectares of forest restoration.
- **7. National Mission for Sustainable Agriculture:** Developing climate-resilient crop varieties and micro-irrigation systems.
- **8. National Mission on Strategic Knowledge for Climate Change:** Climate research modeling, data collection, and institutional capacity building.

International Solar Leadership (ISA & Net-Zero 2070)

- **International Solar Alliance (ISA, 2015):**
  - Co-founded by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French President François Hollande at the COP21 Paris Summit in November 2015.
  - Dedicated to mobilizing over $1,000 billion in solar investment across solar-resource-rich countries situated between the Tropics of Cancer and Capricorn (**"Suryaputras"**).
  - **First treaty-based intergovernmental organization headquartered in India (Gurugram, Haryana).**
- **Panchamrit Commitments (COP26 Glasgow, 2021):**
  - Achieve 500 GW of non-fossil energy capacity by 2030.
  - Meet 50% of energy requirements from renewable energy by 2030.
  - Reduce total projected carbon emissions by one billion tonnes by 2030.
  - Reduce the carbon intensity of the economy by 45% by 2030.
  - Achieve the target of **Net-Zero Carbon Emissions by 2070**.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture



Figure 1: Environment & Natural Resources Mindmap: Global green norms, Rio Earth Summit, CBDR, the four Global Commons, resource geopolitics, and India's climate strategy.

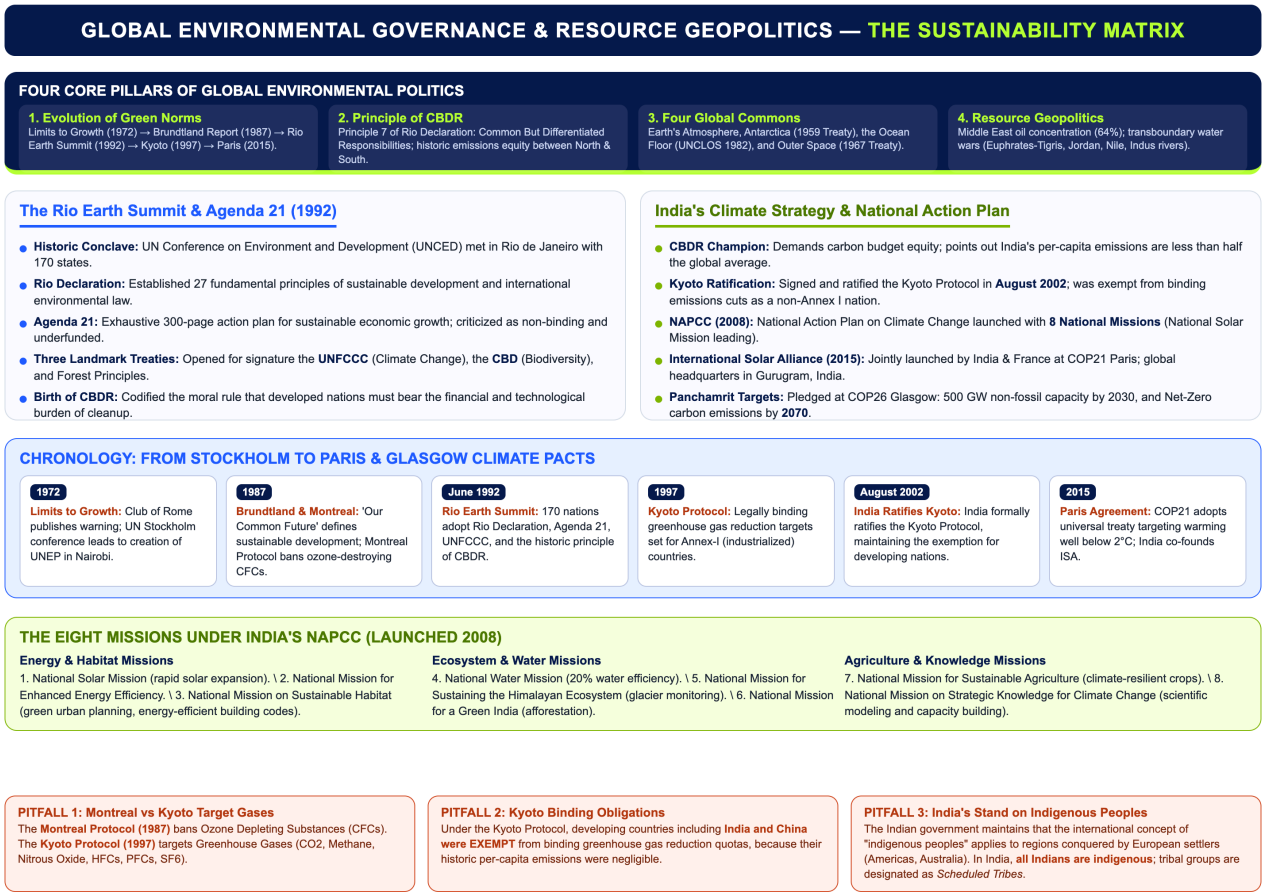


Figure 2: Sustainability Matrix: Evolution of environmental pacts (Stockholm to Paris), NAPCC 8 missions, Global Commons treaties, and key exam pitfalls.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. The landmark 1972 report published by the Club of Rome warning against industrial resource exhaustion and population collapse was titled:

(A) Silent Spring
(B) Our Common Future
(C) The Limits to Growth
(D) Agenda 21

Q2. In which year did the historic Brundtland Commission publish its report 'Our Common Future', popularizing the concept of sustainable development?

(A) 1972
(B) 1987
(C) 1992
(D) 1997

Q3. The United Nations Conference on Environment and Development (UNCED), popularly known as the Earth Summit, was held in 1992 in which city?

(A) Stockholm, Sweden
(B) Kyoto, Japan
(C) Rio de Janeiro, Brazil
(D) Johannesburg, South Africa

Q4. Under the Rio Declaration, which fundamental principle established that developed nations bear a higher moral and legal burden for cleaning up the global environment?

(A) Absolute Sovereignty Principle
(B) Common But Differentiated Responsibilities (CBDR)
(C) Precautionary Principle
(D) Polluter Never Pays Principle

Q5. In which year did India formally sign and ratify the Kyoto Protocol on climate change?

(A) 1997
(B) 2000
(C) August 2002
(D) December 2015

Q6. Which of the following is NOT one of the four internationally recognized 'Global Commons'?

(A) Earth's Atmosphere
(B) Antarctica
(C) The Ocean Floor
(D) The Amazon Rainforest

Q7. The 1987 Montreal Protocol was a landmark international treaty specifically adopted to address which environmental crisis?

(A) Global Greenhouse Gas Emissions
(B) Depletion of the Stratospheric Ozone Layer
(C) Trade in Endangered Species
(D) Disposal of Hazardous Chemical Waste

Q8. The Persian Gulf region in the Middle East accounts for approximately what percentage of the world's total known petroleum oil reserves?

(A) Barely 15%
(B) Nearly 30%
(C) Roughly 64%
(D) Over 90%

Q9. How many national missions were formulated under India's National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC) launched in June 2008?

(A) 5 Missions
(B) 8 Missions
(C) 10 Missions
(D) 12 Missions

Q10. Where is the permanent global headquarters of the treaty-based International Solar Alliance (ISA), co-founded by India and France in 2015, located?

(A) Paris, France
(B) New Delhi, India
(C) Gurugram, India
(D) Nairobi, Kenya

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. The Club of Rome, an international group of scientists and economists, published 'The Limits to Growth' in 1972, predicting resource depletion from unchecked growth.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q2. The Brundtland Commission (World Commission on Environment and Development) released 'Our Common Future' in 1987, defining sustainable development for the world.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. The UN Earth Summit (UNCED) convened in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, in June 1992, adopting the Rio Declaration, Agenda 21, and the UNFCCC on climate change.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q4. Principle 7 of the Rio Declaration articulated Common But Differentiated Responsibilities (CBDR), acknowledging developed nations' historical emissions debt.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q5. India signed and ratified the Kyoto Protocol in August 2002; as a developing nation, India was exempt from mandatory emission reduction targets under the protocol.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. The four recognized Global Commons are: the Earth's Atmosphere, Antarctica, the Ocean Floor, and Outer Space. The Amazon Rainforest falls under sovereign state jurisdiction (mainly Brazil).

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q7. The Montreal Protocol on Substances that Deplete the Ozone Layer was adopted in September 1987, successfully mandating the global phase-out of CFCs.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The Middle East (Persian Gulf) contains approximately 64% of known global oil reserves, making it the strategic cockpit of global energy geopolitics.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q9. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh launched the NAPCC in June 2008 with exactly eight national missions covering solar, water, agriculture, energy efficiency, and ecosystems.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. The International Solar Alliance (ISA) is permanently headquartered at the National Institute of Solar Energy (NISE) campus in Gurugram (Haryana), India.

Answer: (C)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q1 option B	Confusing 1972 Club of Rome with 1987 Brundtland	'Limits to Growth' was published in 1972; 'Our Common Future' was published in 1987.
Q5 option A	Using the Kyoto adoption year instead of India's ratification	Kyoto was drafted in 1997; India formally ratified it 5 years later in August 2002.
Q6 option D	Calling Amazon a global common	The Amazon is within national sovereign territories (Brazil/ Peru); only areas outside state borders are Global Commons.
Q7 option A	Confusing Montreal with Kyoto	Montreal Protocol (1987) targets **Ozone Depleting CFCs**; Kyoto Protocol (1997) targets **Greenhouse Gases**.
Q10 option B	Selecting New Delhi instead of Gurugram	ISA headquarters is located in **Gurugram** (Haryana), just outside Delhi.

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